

The world of birds

Only a few animals in the world are able to fly – insects, bats, and birds. But none of them is more powerful or skilled than the bird.

Birds spend much of their time looking after, or preening, their feathers to keep them in good condition.

Feathered friends

Birds are the only creatures that have feathers. They use them to fly and to keep warm. Some birds use brightly coloured feathers for display.

Feathers are made up of tiny hair-like barbs that all mesh together.

A rigid “backbone” or quill runs through the centre of the wing feathers to strengthen them for flying.

Feathers

Different feathers have different jobs on a bird.

Outer wing: strong feathers to provide power in flight.

Inner wing: smooth and flat to help flight.

Tail feather: long and thin for steering and balancing during flight.

Body feather: soft and downy to keep a bird warm. Some have exotic colours.

Birds' feet are designed for different purposes, such as climbing, clutching berries, or holding on to branches.